
Public Funding for a Private CACR Staff Access Road

Lisa Lynch <lisa.lynch3@gmail.com>

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To: Keith.WALSH@transport.gov.ie

Cc: info@transport.gov.ie, Adrian o'sullivan <adrian.browndog@gmail.com>

Dear Mr Walsh, Assistant Secretary at the Department of Transport,

I am writing to you as a directly affected resident near Ballyrichard, Carrigtwohill, Co. Cork, regarding Irish Rail's selection of Option 7 as the preferred depot access road for the Cork Area Commuter Rail (CACR) maintenance facility. This proposal was developed by Roughan & O'Donovan Consulting Engineers on behalf of Irish Rail and has been met with overwhelming public opposition from East Cork. I am raising this with your division because I believe a fundamental question of public benefit has not been adequately addressed in the option selection process: Option 7, as selected, would deliver a new road for the exclusive use of Irish Rail staff and operational vehicles. The public will not benefit.

Public money, private road

Option 7 requires the construction of over 1km of new road through agricultural land — acknowledged in Irish Rail's own Option Selection Report as requiring construction materials and embodied carbon. This road would serve one purpose: providing access to a maintenance depot. It will carry Irish Rail staff and low-loaders. It will not reduce congestion, provide an alternative route for the public, or connect any community. It is, in effect, a private access road funded from public infrastructure budgets.

Other options assessed by Irish Rail would deliver road infrastructure with genuine public benefit. For example, Option 4, would upgrade a bridge and breen adjacent to the N25 that could serve as an alternative emergency route for eastbound traffic in the Carrigtwohill to Midleton corridor — a corridor where the N25 Carrigtwohill to Midleton Upgrade Scheme has not been allocated funding, leaving the public without a credible timeline for addressing what is already a congested and unsafe stretch of road. In the event of an incident on the N25, there is currently no viable alternative route. Option 4 would change that. Option 7 would not.

A safety concern Irish Rail's own report acknowledges

Irish Rail's flawed Option Selection Report separately records, under the heading for Option 7, that this option "introduces HGVs and Low-loader traffic to residential area." has a "Positive Impact" on Safety. A road investment that worsens residential road safety should require stronger justification than a narrow overall margin of preference.

The ask

I ask that the Department, in its oversight of road policy and investment, satisfy itself that public funding committed to this project is being directed toward infrastructure that delivers meaningful public benefit — and that the concerns of affected residents are raised formally with Irish Rail's board before any route is confirmed. The public consultation closes on 19 June 2026.

Full technical grounds, source document references, and further detail are available on our Community Website: (<https://no2option7.org/technical-evidence.html>)

I would welcome the opportunity to discuss this further.

Yours sincerely,

Lisa Lynch,

Ballyrichard,

Midleton,

Co Cork. P25RD60